Motivating Employees

Tips and Tactics for Supervisors

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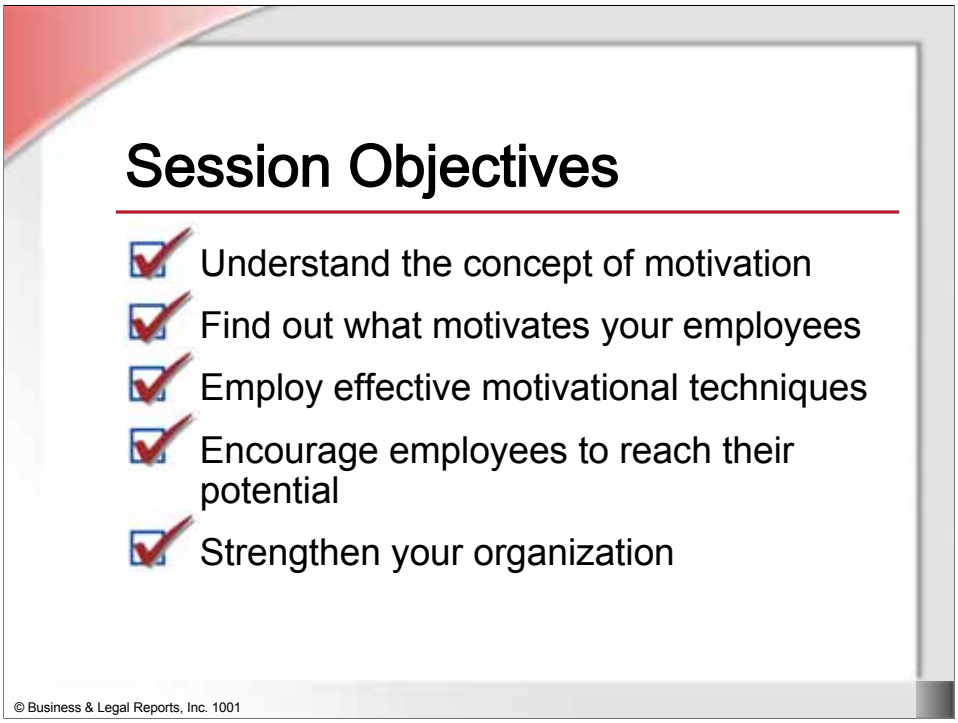
We probably all agree that a motivated workforce is important, maybe even essential, to the success of a business or any other enterprise. Your workplace may offer a revolutionary product or a service people desperately need or you may lack real competition and have plenty of working capital on hand, but without employees who care about the organization and take a vested interest in their own performance, your success is far from assured.

However, motivation is also a murky subject. It seems intangible and hard to pin down. What is it exactly, and how can it be developed or inspired at your workplace?

Fortunately, managers and supervisors can foster motivation among employees simply by understanding the nature of motivation and using tested techniques designed to motivate. We will discuss the nature of motivation and study motivational techniques in this training session.



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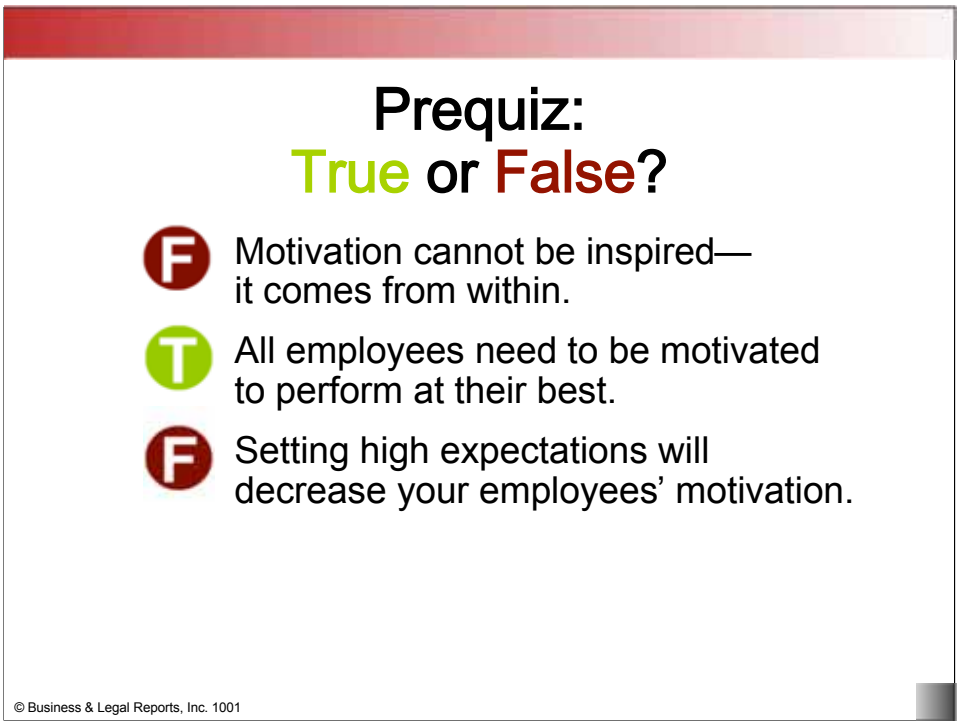
- We'll begin the session by seeking a better understanding of the concept of motivation. This means more than just knowing a definition. It also entails knowing some of the qualities of motivation and thinking about how motivation relates to the health of your organization. That's a tall order, but we'll get started today.
- You'll also need to find out what motivates your employees. Again, this may be more complex than it initially seems because people are motivated by different factors. We'll discuss many of these factors.
- Then, we will focus on a variety of effective techniques to help you obtain peak performance from your employees.
- We'll also talk about ways you can encourage your employees to grow and reach their highest potential. As you'll see, one important aspect of motivation is that it benefits both the organization and the employee. That's a point to stress with the employees you talk to, supervise, or train.
- Finally, we will leave you thinking by ending the training session with an interactive case study in which you can apply what you have learned.



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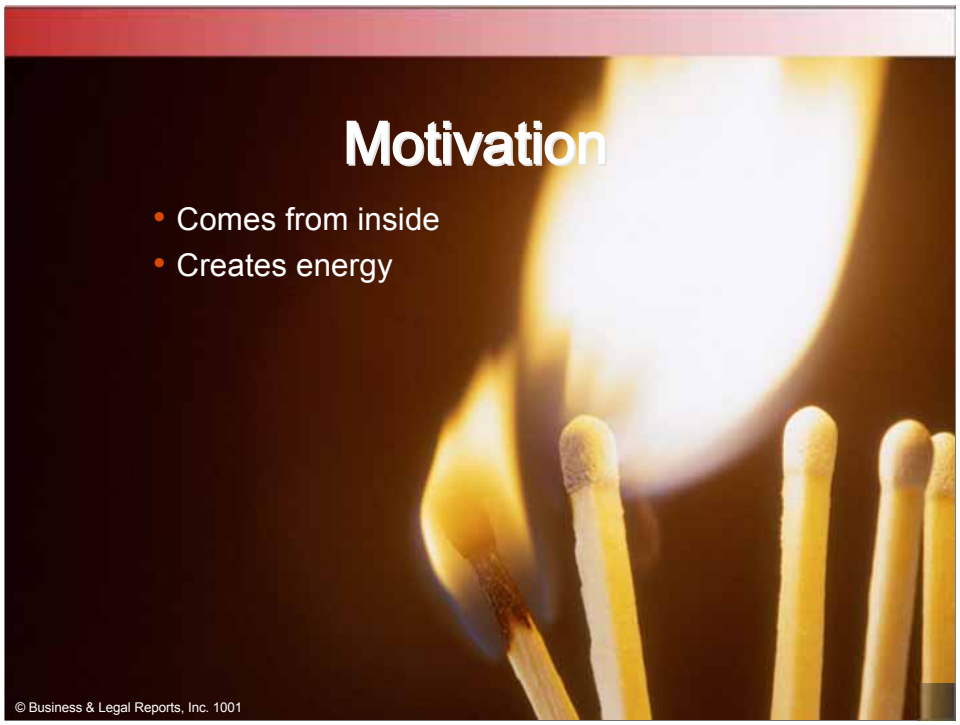
Before we begin the session, let's take a few minutes to see how much you already know about motivation. Decide whether each statement on the screen is *true* or *false*.

Now, let's review the answers.

- Motivation cannot be inspired—it comes from within—this is *false*.
- All employees need to be motivated to perform at their best—this is *true*.
- Setting high expectations will decrease your employees' motivation—this is *false*.

How did you do? Did you get all the answers right? If not, don't worry. You'll learn all about these issues and a lot more during the session.



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- "Motivation comes from within." That's an old expression you have probably heard before. When you think of a motivated person, you may imagine someone who seems to have an inner fire that fuels them. These people seem about to overcome any obstacles in their way.
- Motivated people are usually interested in improving their own performance, and often, the performance of the organization they are part of. While they seem to be expending a lot of energy—and they are!—it is useful to note that motivation itself can create energy. Think of times in your life when you were especially motivated. How was your energy level?

Take a moment to listen to answers to this question.

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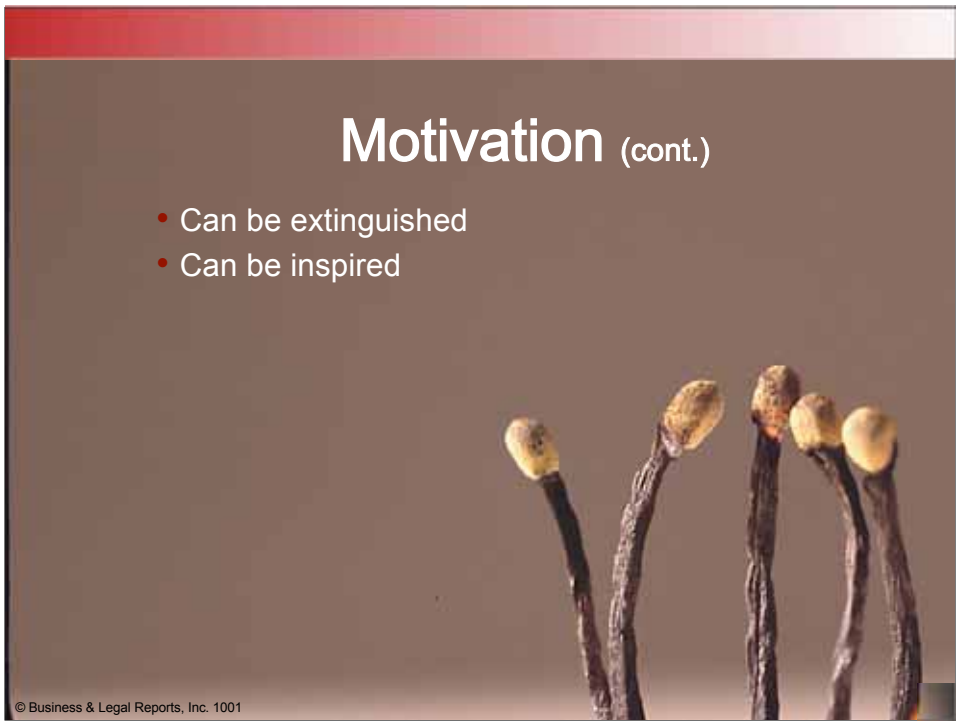
- This brings us to another important point about motivation: You can feel it. Motivation may be partly a way of thinking, but it can often be felt in the body, too. In fact, it is probably not going too far to say that it is a force that binds all parts of us in a common purpose.
- Motivated people aren't easily discouraged. In fact, one of the traits of motivation is that it is a commitment to solve problems and overcome obstacles. This doesn't mean that a motivated person will always succeed, but the commitment to make every effort is there.
- That's why motivated people are more likely to succeed in the end, and motivation is likely to lead to accomplishment. The motivated person does not give up easily and is willing to persevere to accomplish the task at hand or fulfill a goal or dream.

Discuss the concept and traits of motivation with trainees. Ask for examples of motivated behavior from their own experiences.



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- Although motivation is an inner force, it is also affected by outward circumstance and the climate around us. Motivation can be crushed by failure, but even people who succeed can lose their motivation if they are not respected or rewarded. We probably all know cases of people who started a job with a great deal of energy and willingness to learn, reached a certain level of accomplishment, and then stopped. Perhaps these people lost their motivation. The fire was dampened, or extinguished.
- However, motivation can also be inspired by events, circumstances, or encouraging words or actions. Think of times in your own work experiences where a kind word from a supervisor, a raise in pay, or some other factor caused the fire of motivation inside you to flare up again.

Discuss how motivation is affected by outside circumstances, events, or other people. Ask for examples from trainees' experiences.

Motivational Techniques…

- Develop skilled workers
- Encourage high performance
- Create an effective team
- Foster job satisfaction and personal growth

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Because motivation among workers can be reduced or heightened by the actions of others, the steps taken by managers are especially important. That's why it is important to rely on tested techniques that will heighten motivation, rather than dampen it. Using proven motivational techniques will have several benefits:

- First, you will develop skilled, knowledgeable, and productive workers who can take initiative and get the job done.
- You will be encouraging high-quality performance, with all employees working up to their potential.
- At the same time, you'll create an effective team, with each employee pulling his or her weight and taking pleasure in the way they function together.
- You'll also help employees find greater job satisfaction, increasing enthusiasm and involvement and reducing turnover. Motivated workers will experience personal growth as they improve their skills and meet new challenges.

Motivational Techniques…
(cont.)

- Encourage advancement
- Improve the culture
- Prepare for future needs

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- By using these motivational techniques, you'll encourage employees to advance within your work group or by moving into other departments. This strengthens the entire organization, as well as helping to retain good employees.
- You will also improve the culture of the organization by fostering learning, growth, and achievement.
- And, you will prepare to meet future needs by creating a more skilled, engaged workforce that wants the organization to succeed.

Discuss the benefits of a motivated workforce and why it is important to the health of an organization.

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All employees need to be motivated to perform at their best. The tendency is to focus motivational efforts on problem employees, but the fact is that even your best performers need to be motivated to continue to work up to their potential.

Money, of course, is an important motivator for most employees. But it isn't the only one. And it may be one over which you have little practical control. During this session, therefore, we will focus on other motivators, ones you have more control over and can use effectively on a daily basis.

- It's important to keep in mind that motivators vary from person to person. What motivates one employee might not work with another.
- That's why you need to get to know your workers and find out what actually motivates each of them. If you have trouble determining an employee's motivators, ask that person to tell you what would make them more excited about their job. People are generally the best judge of what motivates them, so go right to the source. If an employee seems hesitant or unsure, suggest several different motivators and get their reactions.
- Many times, using a combination of motivational techniques yields the best results. You may also find that you need to change motivators when an employee's circumstances or goals change.

Ask trainees what they find motivating and discuss the answers.

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If you ask employees what they really want from their jobs, they'd probably mention many of the things that you see on this and the next screen. In survey after survey, employees in all types of work express these same desires. They want:

- Good supervision from a leader who can guide and direct their activity;
- Clear goals and expectations that are mutually understood and agreed upon;
- Accurate and timely feedback that fairly reflects their performance and helps them improve it;
- Interesting work, or at least the opportunity for interesting assignments from time to time;
- Challenges that help them learn, grow, and test their talents and stretch their abilities;
- Responsibility and the chance to take on important tasks and show what they can do.
- And finally, recognition for their efforts in the form of praise, rewards, and advancement.

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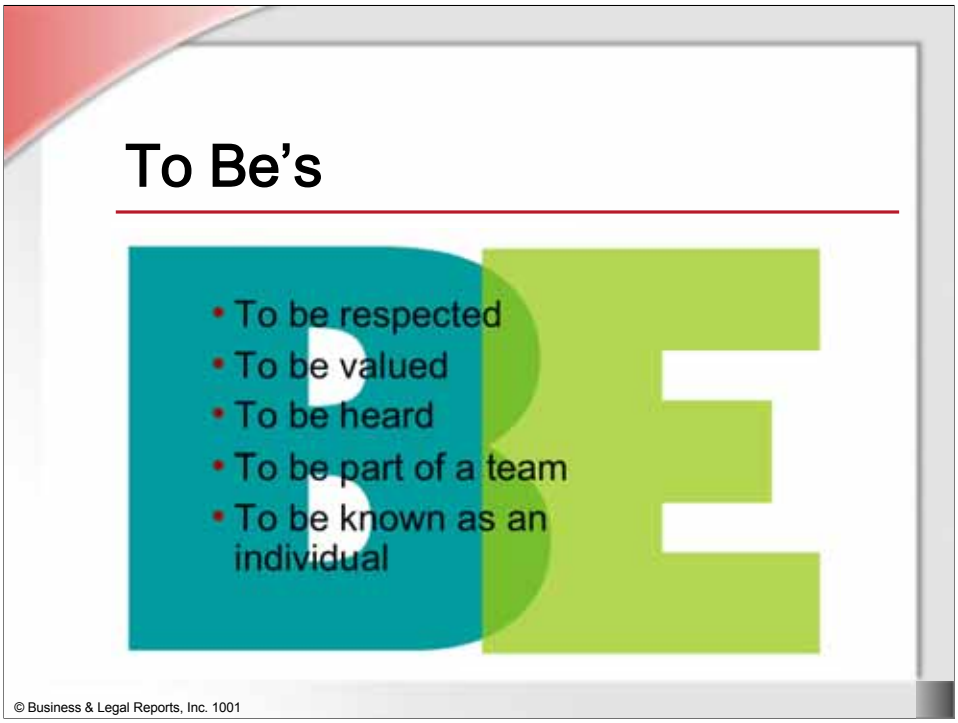
In addition, employees want:

- Accurate information about what's going on in the department and the organization;
- Fair treatment in evaluation, recognition, responsibilities, and so on;
- Opportunities for growth and advancement;
- To have some control over their work and the authority to take initiative and make decisions within prescribed boundaries;
- And finally, participation in decisionmaking that affects their work and their work group.

Discuss what employees want from their jobs, including any additions to this list.



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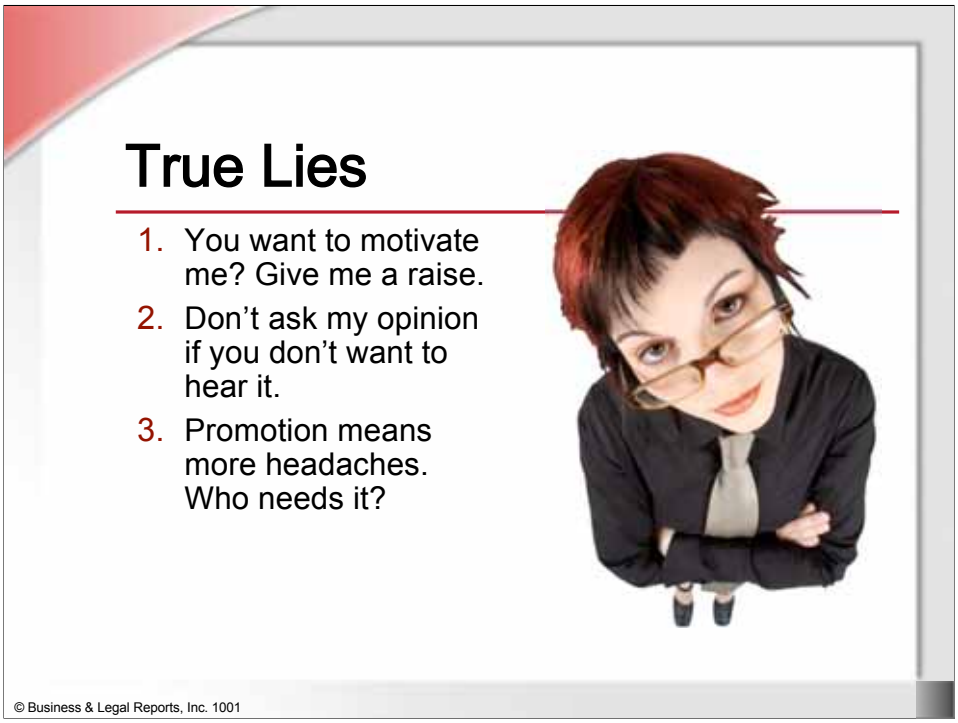
We can distill all this thinking about what employees want down to a few phrases beginning with "to be":

- To be respected by everyone at the workplace;
- To be valued by the organization, and to be told and shown that they are valued;
- To be heard: Even if not all their ideas are adopted and not all their requests can be met, employees want the chance to speak to sympathetic listeners;
- To be part of a team: Most employees enjoy the camaraderie and sense of achievement that come from being part of a successful team. Even employees who like to work alone can take pride in the success of a work team or the whole organization;
- To be known as individuals: Even the best team players want to have their strengths and abilities seen and appreciated by supervisors and peers.



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Now that we've started learning more about what employees want, let's think together about some of the things you may hear them say. We've labeled these statements "True Lies," because while there is some truth in each of them, they may not provide the whole story or all the truth. Read each of these statements and imagine an employee saying it. Then, jot down some notes about what you see or hear in the statement and how a supervisor should respond.

1. You want to motivate me? Give me a raise.
2. Don't ask my opinion if you don't want to hear it.
3. Promotion means more headaches. Who needs it?

Allow trainees some time to think or write about the statements, then discuss each statement with them.

True Lies Discussion

Employee Complaint	Supervisor Response
If you want to motivate me, give me a raise.	Would anything else motivate?
Don't ask my opinion if you don't want to hear it.	Not all ideas can be pursued.
Promotion means more headaches. Who needs it?	Support is provided.

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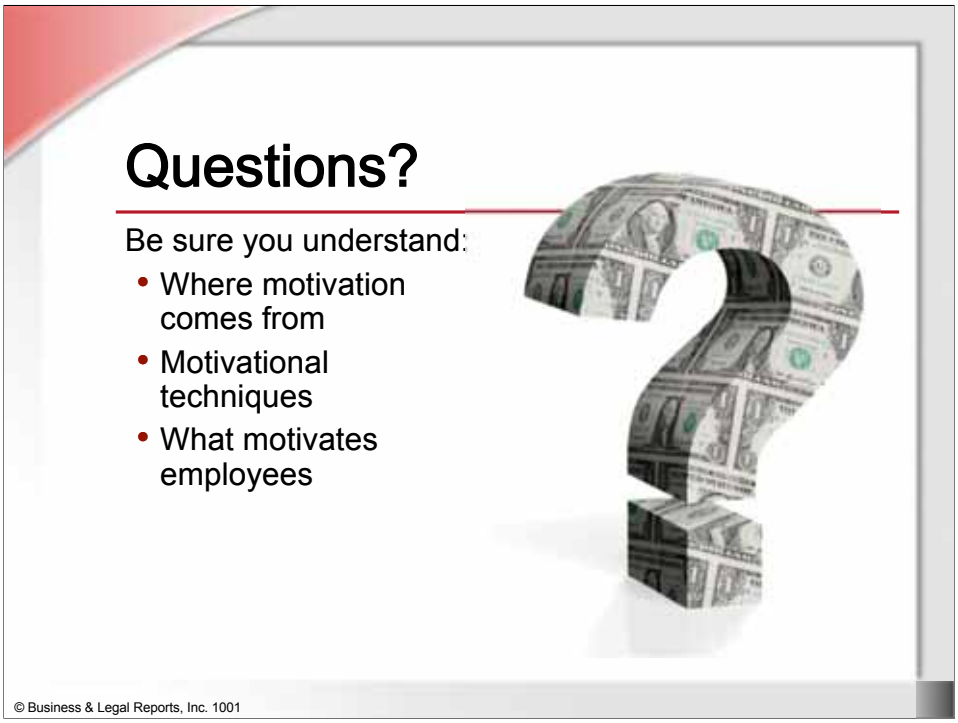
Now, let's go over some responses for these scenarios.

- ***If you want to motivate me, give me a raise.*** Employees often see money as the key to motivation, and sometimes it is. If you cannot grant a raise, you may want to ask the employee if anything else would inspire motivation. You may find that at times employees who want a raise can also be motivated by other means.
- ***Don't ask my opinion if you don't want to hear it.*** Employees who make this or similar statements may be upset because their ideas were not adopted by the group or the organization. Talk with employees openly about their ideas and the ideas of others. Explain that while all the ideas were worthwhile, only some could be pursued at this time. Make sure employees understand that their participation is always valued and will be needed again.
- ***Promotion means more headaches. Who needs it?*** Employees may be frustrated by not advancing or may be intimidated by the idea of advancement or promotion. Respond by talking to these employees about why advancement is important, to their careers and to the organization. Talk about the support that is provided for employees who are promoted, or want to be. Share with them some of the satisfactions or rewards that may make the headaches worth it and make sure they understand that you have confidence in them to make the best of any new roles.



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At this point, be sure you understand about:

- Where motivation comes from,
- Motivational techniques, *and*
- What motivates employees.

Take questions from the group.

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Now let's focus on how to motivate employees. As a leader in the organization, you can demonstrate motivation in many ways and foster it in others.

- To motivate your employees to work harder and smarter, you need to help them see how they fit into the big picture and recognize their parts in the organization's mission. When people share a vision of the future, they are inspired to achieve.
- To do their jobs effectively, employees need direction. They need to know the parameters of successful performance. They need a leader to guide their activities and ideas to successful completion.
- People bond by a shared commitment to goals. You can encourage this commitment in your employees by example: by being committed to department and organizational goals yourself, and expecting commitment from each employee.
- To successfully motivate employees, they must know that you care about them. They need to know that you are there for them when they need support and assistance, when they experience problems, or want you to listen to their ideas. Accessibility is a cornerstone of motivation.
- You can motivate your workers only if they trust you. They need to know that you stand behind your promises, that you can be relied on under any circumstances, and that you place a high priority on their welfare.

Discuss how the actions of organizational leaders can increase, or reduce, employee motivation.

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- The best teachers hold high expectations for their students, and studies have proven that these high expectations are usually met with high achievement. The same principles hold for the workplace. Expect little from your workers, and that's what you'll probably get. Expect the best from each employee, and that's what you'll get.
- Setting goals is an excellent way to motivate employees. If you give them a direction in which to head and a measurable result to achieve, you hand them a road map for achievement. The most successful motivational goals are those that are set high enough to be challenging, but reasonable enough to be achieved.
- Standards must be consistent so that everyone will know exactly what is required in every situation. Otherwise, instead of guiding and motivating employees, your standards will only cause confusion and dissension, and damage the integrity and quality of your group's work.

Discuss how to convey high expectations and set and communicate goals and standards.

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Involvement is another key to motivation. The more involved employees are in their work and the operation of their work groups, the more motivated they are to work hard and perform well.

- Participation is a powerful motivator. Involve employees in planning, decision making, and problem solving. Make them active members of a team to which everyone makes an important contribution.
- Delegation is another highly effective motivator. Put somebody in charge of achieving a result, make them accountable for accomplishing a goal, and you give them a strong incentive to perform at their very best.
- Creating an atmosphere in which employees feel ownership for their work is also a successful motivational technique. People want to feel proud of their work. They want to be trusted to make the right decisions and take appropriate action to achieve positive, meaningful results.
- Information flow is an essential part of keeping employees motivated. Your workers want to be kept informed about what is going on and how they fit into it. They also want to be able to share their ideas with you and their co-workers. Two-way communication helps keep employees involved.

Discuss these and other ways to keep employees involved.

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Not all jobs are extremely interesting. But if you wish to motivate your workers and keep them involved in their work, you must try to make every job, even the most routine tasks, more interesting. There are many ways to do this, among them:

- Challenge employees to find better, more efficient ways to perform routine jobs;
- Cross-train and rotate less interesting jobs when possible. Even a dull job is more interesting when it is new to an employee;
- Broaden an employee's responsibilities to include planning, problem solving, quality control, or other more challenging aspects of the job sequence;
- Or, form workers into a team and make the team responsible for an entire operation or project from start to finish. Let them decide how the work is divided and how it is done, as long as desired results are achieved on schedule.

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- Another effective way to motivate employees through challenge is to expose them to new experiences. New experiences are always interesting—whether or not we like them. When people are exposed to work they haven't done before, they are forced to think and act in new ways, which is ultimately stimulating, satisfying, and growth inducing.
- Problem solving is also a great motivator. People like to fix things, solve puzzles, or make things work. We do this in our personal lives all the time. It's a skill that is easily transferred to work, and it is perhaps the most self-reinforcing motivator of them all. Once employees have been given a chance to solve a problem, they often look forward to tackling another one.
- Although most employees will welcome challenges, some may be intimidated at first. They may express a desire to stick with the safe and familiar. For some of these people, you may need to rely on other motivators. But others may just be cautious or afraid of failure. You can bring these people along slowly, giving them challenges they feel they can handle, gradually increasing the difficulty and importance of the challenge.

Discuss how to challenge workers, including how to match challenges to workers.

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- Everyone needs to belong in some degree to a group. It's human nature. You can make use of this quality in the workplace by creating a team spirit among your employees. Make everyone feel that he or she is an important member of the team, with a significant role to play and an essential contribution to make.
- Once you have molded your workforce into an effective team, you have access to a built-in motivator. We may call this by that old familiar term, "peer pressure," but perhaps a more accurate term is "peer esteem." Everyone wants the team to look good, and everyone wants to be respected by their peers. While the pressure to do one's best may be imposed by the members of a team, this pressure is also self-imposed.
- Supervisors can teach team members to provide encouragement to one another and make sure that the team is welcoming both to new members and longtime members who are striving to improve their performance. Members of teams can motivate one another in a climate of support, where high standards are met through cooperation, rather than competition.

Discuss how to build a team, including experiences trainees have had with teambuilding.

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- Everyone needs to feel important. To the extent you can make each employee who works for you feel important, you will be providing considerable motivation for your employees to work hard and succeed. The best way to make people feel important is to show that you value and respect them.
- Treat your employees as the professionals they are. Respect their efforts, expertise, and talents. It's not necessary for you to like every one of your employees. But it's essential for you to respect them all.
- Get to know your employees as individuals. This tells them that they are more than just one of the crowd. It shows that you respect them and care about them. The benefits that flow from this kind of working relationship are highly motivational.
- Finally, when people work hard and do a good job, they want someone to notice and to give them a pat on the back. Show respect and appreciation for employees' work. Let them know how important their effort is to you.

With help from trainees, list ways to get to know your employees and to show them respect and appreciation.

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- The old saying "A little praise goes a long way" certainly applies to employee motivation. Whenever you can give an employee positive feedback about performance, you are motivating that employee to perform even better. This is true whether you are praising someone for a job well done or correcting a mistake.
- Public praise is another way to motivate many employees. People like others to know about their successes. Employee of the Month programs, newsletter notices, and bulletin board announcements are all effective means of using public praise to enhance performance.
- Money, of course, is always a welcome form of recognition and reward for quality performance. To the extent that you have control over raises and promotions, you can use this tool very effectively to motivate many employees.
- There are also many other types of rewards that employees find motivational. For example:
  - Special privileges, more responsibility;
  - Release from a task they don't like, or assignment to a task they do like;
  - More authority;
  - Appointment to committees and task forces; *and*
  - Special training.

Discuss methods of recognition that the trainees have used with success.

Opportunities for Growth

- Develop knowledge and skills
- Broaden experiences
- Prepare for advancement

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Most of your employees are looking to get ahead. They want to be promoted and get the jobs they aspire to. Helping them to grow and prepare for available opportunities can motivate them to work hard for you, even if it means that eventually they will move out of your work group.

- Encouraging employees to learn new skills on the job helps keep the work interesting and challenging as well as preparing employees for better job opportunities—in your department or elsewhere in the organization.
- Along with more skills, employees need to have as many different work experiences as possible to develop their judgment and expertise. Whenever possible, create opportunities within your group. This way, you can encourage employees to keep growing without losing them to another department or another organization. Some employees don't want to move up the ladder. What they really want is for you to enhance the job they already have so that they can continue to find fulfillment and challenge doing what they love most.
- Other employees want to move up as quickly as possible. If these workers understand that everything they do is in some way preparing them for advancement, they will be motivated to perform at their best each step along the way. This is more evidence that knowing your employees is important: If you know their ambitions and career goals, you will better recognize how to motivate them.

Ask trainees to talk about how opportunities for growth have helped them or others.

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You can help employees grow and prepare for advancement, while keeping them motivated to do a good job with the work they have now, through training.

- Employees should always have sufficient training to learn the skills required to perform their jobs well. Nothing will discourage a worker faster than wanting to do a good job but not having the skills to perform up to expectation.
- Having the opportunity to learn advanced skills that will prepare them to take on more responsibilities and challenges can also be highly motivating.
- Cross-training is another effective motivator that allows employees to gain new skills, have different experiences, enjoy some variety in their routines, and gain a better understanding of their co-workers' needs and problems.
- Send employees out of the department for training whenever possible to workplace-sponsored training sessions or outside seminars. These events give employees exposure to new ideas and techniques as well as to people in other parts of the organizations or other organizations in your industry. Organize a panel discussion about what employees learned at a conference or seminar and let them share this new knowledge with others.
- Encourage employees to further their education on their own as well. Suggest that they take courses or work toward a degree. Even if the courses aren't directly related to work, the knowledge and confidence gained will be reflected in their performance on the job. Remember, you are helping to develop professionals.

Ask trainees about training or educational opportunities at their workplaces.

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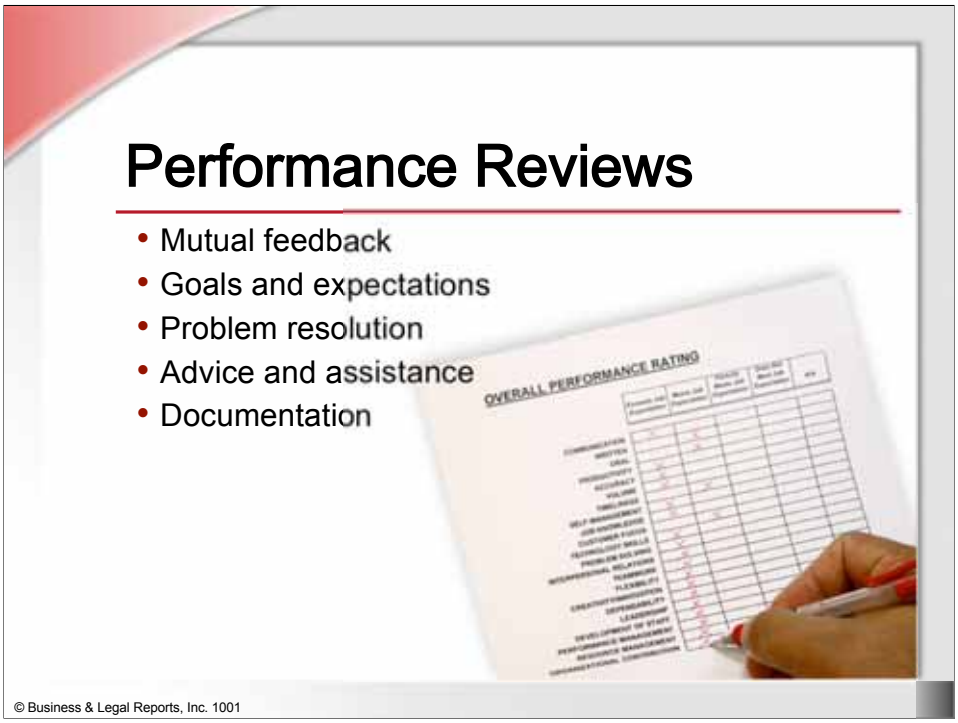
- Coaching employees gives you the opportunity to work with employees individually, to get to know them better, and to find out what they really want from their jobs. It gives employees the chance to meet with you regularly to discuss performance, professional concerns, problems, and opportunities.
- To be motivational, it's important that performance goals be set with each employee. Mutual understanding and agreement is essential. Find out what employees want to work on, what they want to achieve, and where they want to go in the organization, and then base their goals on these issues. This way, employees are choosing their own personal motivators.
- Once goals are set, you need to continue to meet with the employee—weekly, if possible—to monitor performance, provide positive feedback, help solve problems, and adjust goals as necessary. You may also need to arrange for additional training.
- Set a timetable to review progress. Whether it's 3 months, 6 months, or longer, the pressure of meeting a deadline will help keep employees progressing toward their goals.
- As goals are achieved, set new ones and keep the process going. It is time-consuming to coach your employees, but the rewards in terms of skilled, motivated workers are well worth the effort.

Discuss the use of coaching techniques in supervising or motivating employees.



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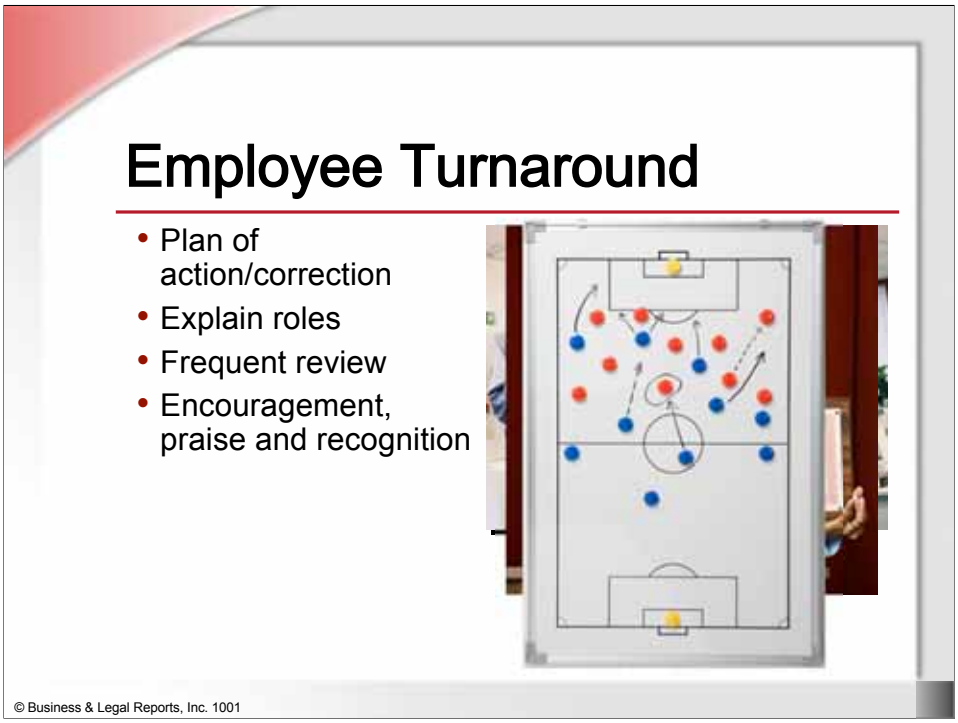
If you are already coaching your employees on a regular basis, formal performance reviews are just another part of that process.

- If formal performance reviews are designed to be objective and interactive, they can give you an excellent opportunity to provide the feedback employees need to improve job performance, and they give employees the chance to tell you how they feel about their jobs and what they want from their work.
- Performance reviews also provide you with a chance to create a better future for you, your employees, and your group. Through the setting of goals and the expression of expectations, you give employees essential guidance and direction. These meetings also give you an opportunity to discuss problems and work with employees to find mutually satisfactory solutions.
- Annual or biannual reviews give you a structured occasion to offer advice and assistance to your employees.
- Finally, make sure that both you and the employee leave the performance review with a document spelling out expectations, goals, and decisions about future performance. This will help avoid any misunderstandings or questions about what needs to be done in the period ahead.

Discuss techniques for effective performance reviews.



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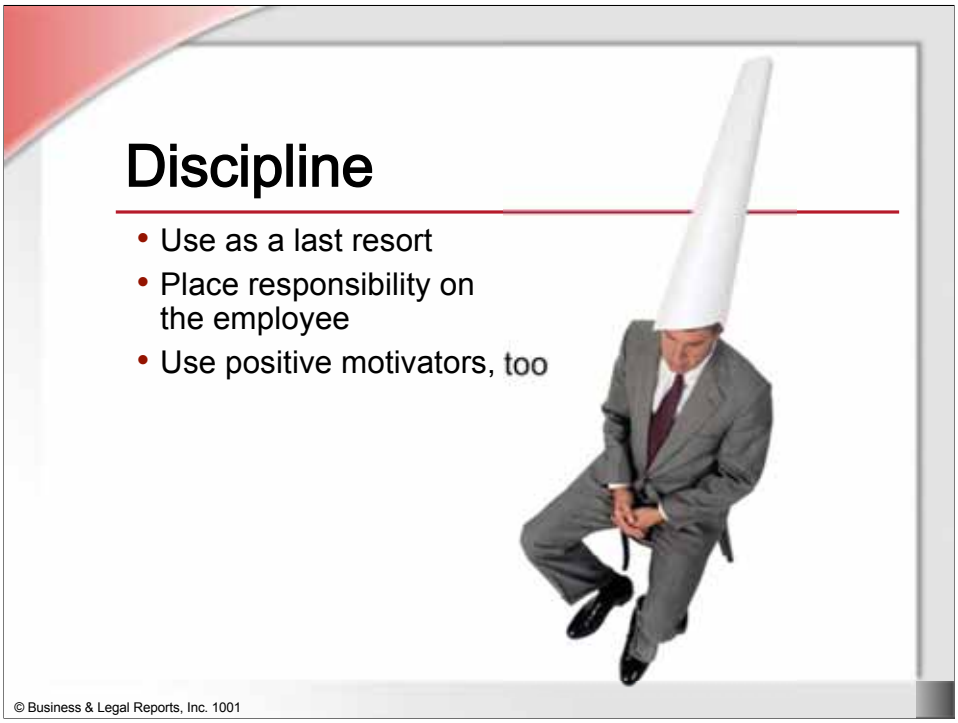
We've stressed how motivational techniques can be used to help employees achieve and meet their career goals while strengthening the organization. However, motivation can also be used in cases where an employee's performance, actions, or attitudes are damaging both their careers and the organization.

- For these employees, a plan of action or correction may be needed. You may try first to come to an agreement about acceptable behaviors through informal discussions. However, if that does not work, meet with the employee and develop a formal, written plan. While it is essential that the organization's expectations are met, it is also important to get input from the employee. This is a chance to listen and find out about the employee's concerns.
- As you develop the plan, clearly explain what the employee needs to do to meet expectations. However, also show what the organization will do to provide support or assistance. Correction works best when it is perceived as a partnership.
- Once the plan is developed, monitor the employee's progress with care and meet frequently with the employee to review the plan and the employee's conduct.
- Provide encouragement, praise, and recognition as the employee's work improves. Make it clear that the employee's value in the workplace is increasing.

Ask trainees about their experiences correcting employee behavior.



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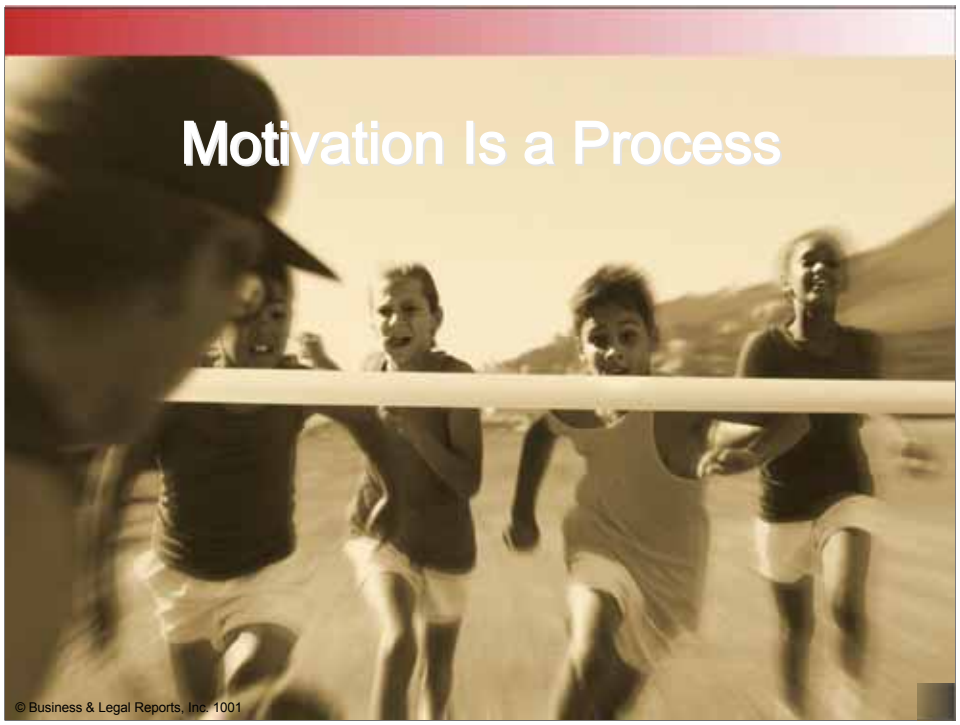
- Some employees are actually motivated by discipline. They don't take their work seriously until they are threatened with some kind of sanction for unacceptable or inadequate performance. But discipline should be used only as a last resort for problem employees who fail to respond to other, positive forms of motivation.
- Make it clear that resorting to discipline is not punishment by you or the organization but a consequence of the employee's own performance and behavior. Put the responsibility squarely on the employee, where it belongs.
- Once you have warned an employee or applied necessary discipline, be sure to use other positive motivators as well to encourage improved performance. Discipline alone is rarely enough to turn a problem employee around.



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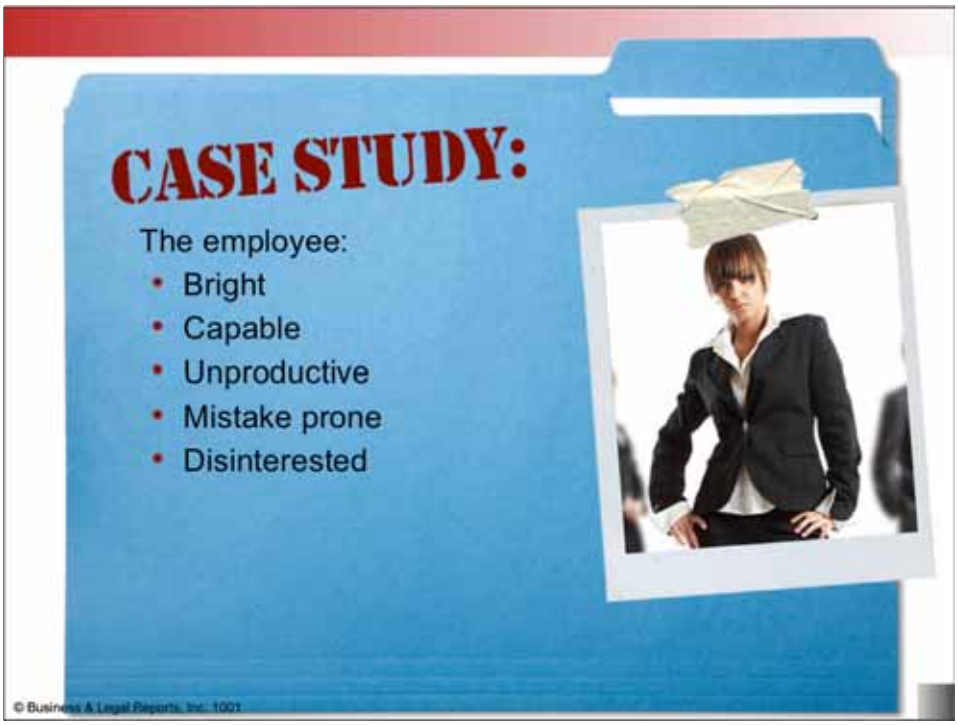
Here's a final thought to keep in mind:

Motivating employees is not something you do one time and then forget about. Instead, it's a process that is always in action and that needs to adjusted for each employee. That's why it is important to continue to listen to your employees, work with them to set goals, monitor their performance, and support and recognize them.

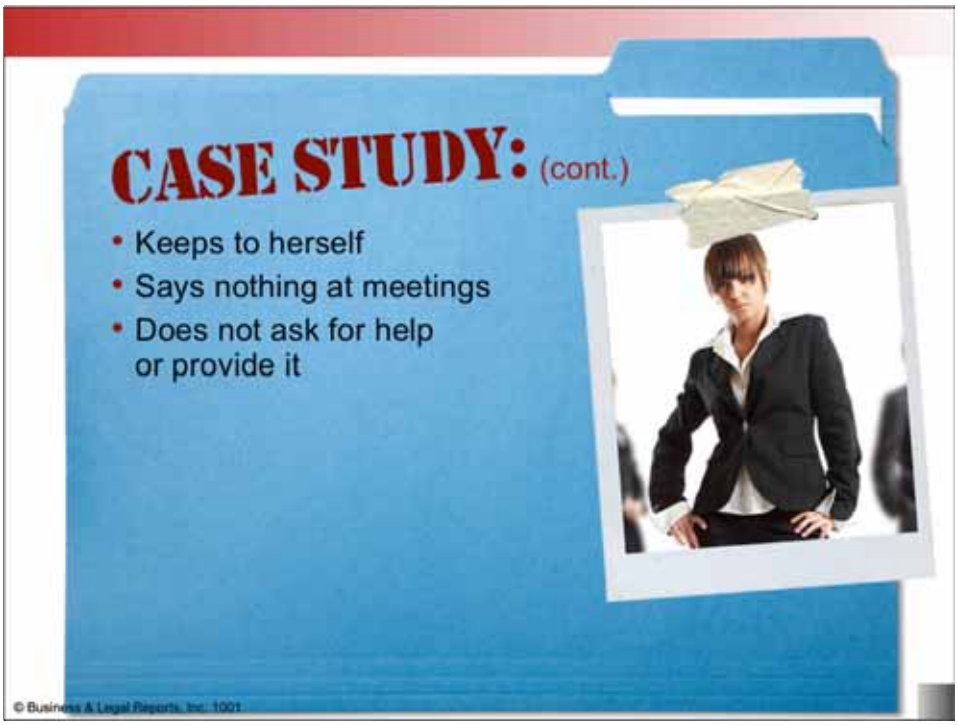
Motivation should be part of everything you do as both a supervisor and supportive colleague.



Slide Show Notes

Let's try another exercise: this time a case study about an employee. Have you ever met someone who refuses to live up to their potential? That's Jackie. She's been with you about a year now.

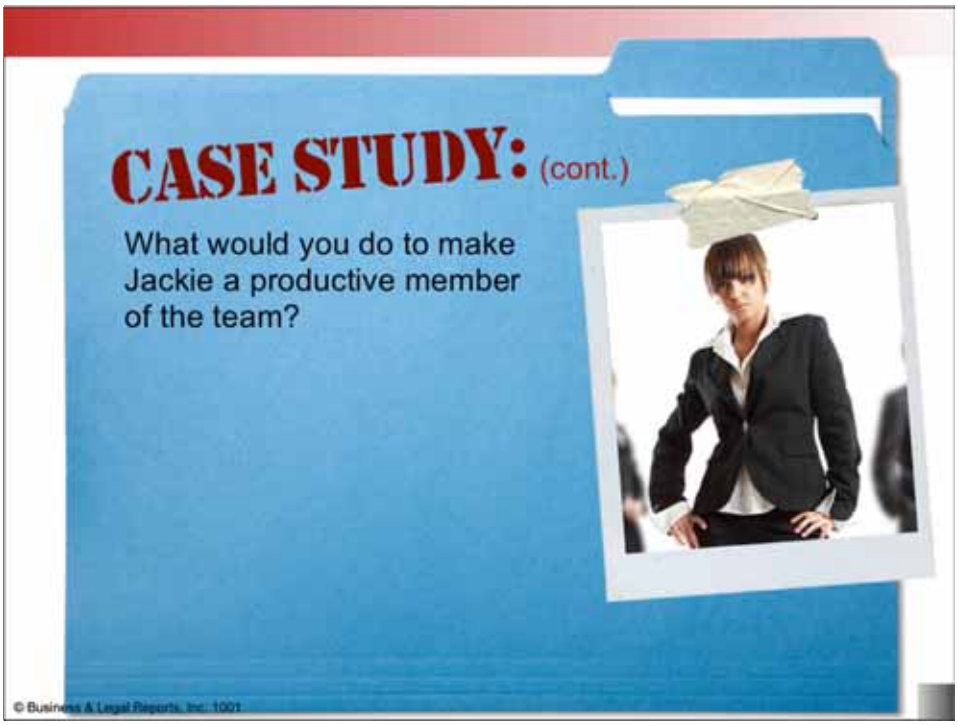
- She's bright and learns quickly.
- She's shown she's capable of mastering the tasks you've assigned to her.
- However, her productivity is low. It's gotten to the point where you have to prod her to get her to finish a task.
- She's also mistake prone; you have to check her work carefully.
- Overall, she seems disinterested, as if she just doesn't care about her job or the organization.



Slide Show Notes

Here's a little more about Jackie:

- She keeps to herself and does not interact much with co-workers.
- She says nothing at most meetings.
- She never asks for help and does not willingly provide it to her co-workers. However, you've heard her on the phone with her friends, and she seems animated and talkative then.

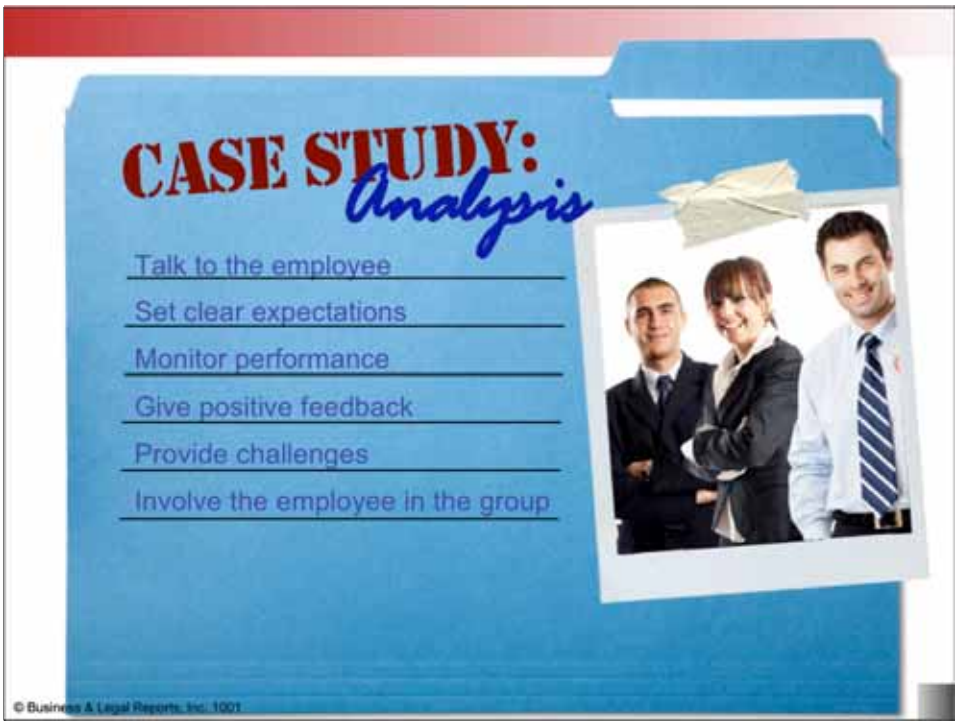


Slide Show Notes

What can the supervisor in this case do to save this employee and turn her into a productive, enthusiastic, cooperative member of the department's team? Which motivational techniques discussed in this training session would be most effective in achieving this goal? What other techniques would you suggest?

Here's a more specific question: What is the first thing you'd do in trying to reach Jackie?

Give trainees time to think about this case or let them talk about it in a group. Then lead a discussion about how they would approach "Jackie" and seek to help her while improving her performance.



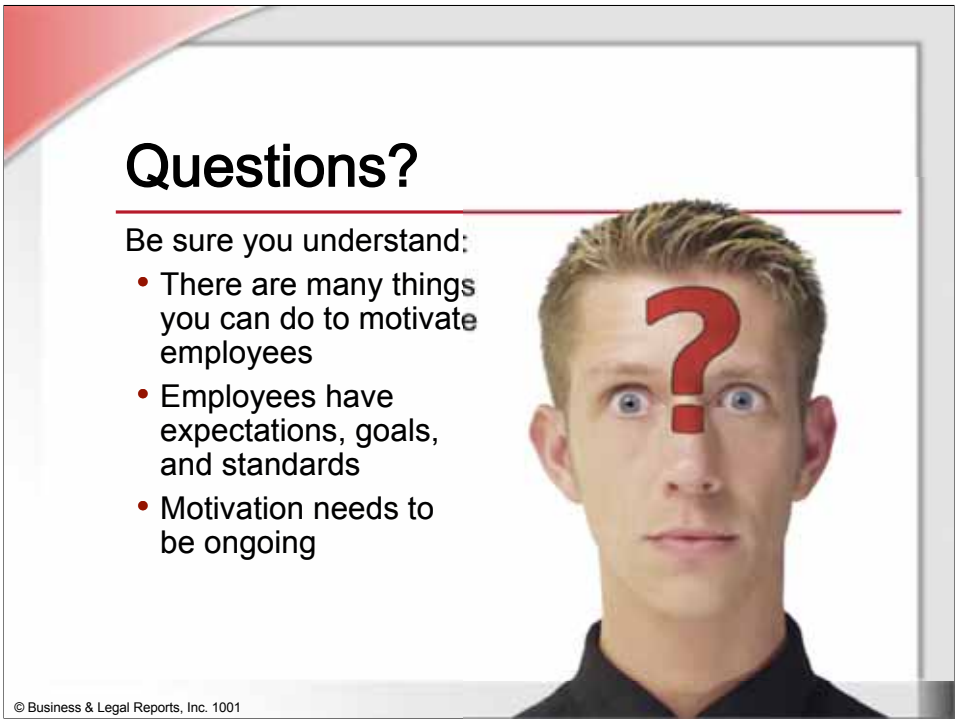
Slide Show Notes

Here's a list of steps that can help you motivate Jackie. They are:

- Talk to Jackie to let her know how important she is to the organization and why you need her effort.
- Set clear expectations—make sure Jackie knows what is expected of her.
- Monitor performance—check back with Jackie in 30 days to see how she is progressing.
- Give positive feedback if you feel Jackie has become more productive.
- Provide challenges so Jackie is not bored or disinterested with her job, *and finally,*
- Involve Jackie in the group—let her know she is an essential part of the team.

Do you have anything you'd like to add to this list?

Discuss this list of steps with trainees.

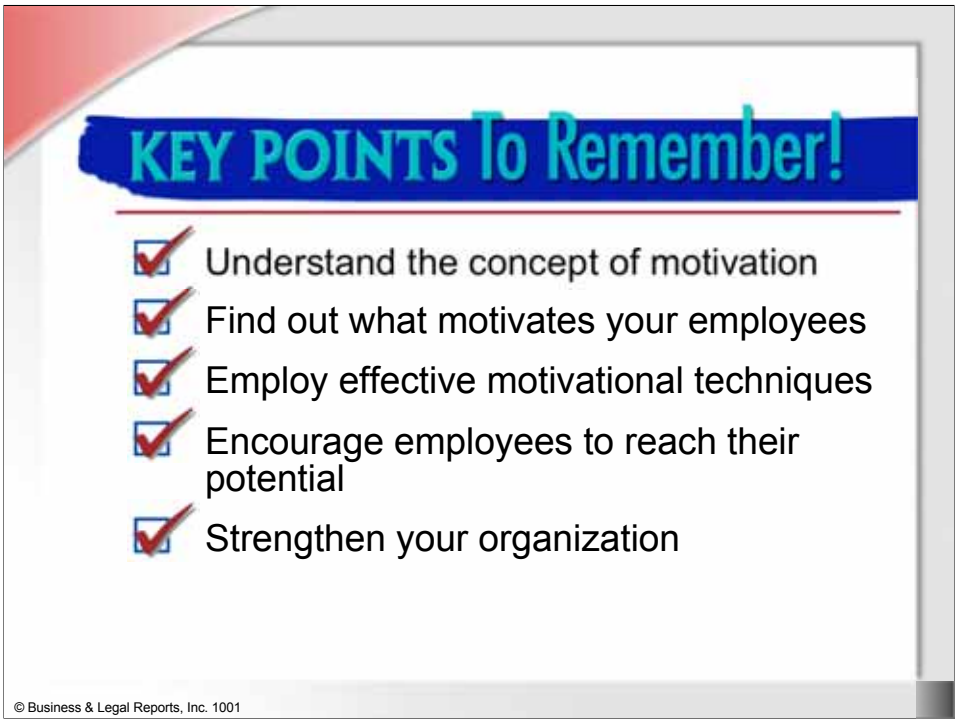


Slide Show Notes

At this point, be sure you understand:

- As a supervisor, there are many things you can do to motivate employees;
- Employees have expectations, goals, and standards that need to be met in order for them to stay motivated; *and*
- Motivation needs to be ongoing—it's not a one-time event.

Take questions from trainees and let others in the group try to answer them, as well as providing your own answers.



Slide Show Notes

- Motivation is a complex subject, and as you try out the techniques we've discussed, you'll find that your understanding of motivation and how to motivate people gradually changes and becomes more refined.
- Here is our list of objectives. Study the list for a moment. Do you feel as if you've made some progress on understanding motivation?
- Are you prepared to learn more about your employees and do you see why this is important?
- Have you discovered some new motivational techniques to employ from the session today?
- Do you understand how motivation can serve your employees well while also strengthening your organization?

Talk with employees about these objectives and make sure they are prepared to employ the techniques they've learned.